

A Princess in Paris

Written by Darshan Jain Goburdhone

Synopsis: In Nazi-occupied Paris, a teenager falls for a peculiar girl hailing from a mysterious kingdom threatened by the Germans.

Characters:

- Albert Garnier
- The Girl
- Sandra Marceux
- Kathryn
- Camille
- Anna
- Albert's father and mother
- Celeste Garnier
- SS-Sturmmann Werner and Hinrich
- Michael
- The Knight

Plot:

Prologue

On a barren land, a young freelance knight stumbles on the wreckage of a golden coach. The horses and the coach's occupants have all been brutally maimed. The knight, whose face is hidden behind his helmet, steps off his horse and rummages through the coach, delighted to find jewelry and gold inside.

After loading his findings into his horse, he hears the wails of a woman, stemming from a cave a few miles away. He draws his sword and approaches the entrance where he sees a pregnant woman, dressed in torn royal clothes, screaming in agony. She's fearful of the knight and has visibly been through something traumatic. And to complicate matters, she is now in labour. The knight retracts his sword and returns to his horse, paying no heed to the woman's cries.

But as he prepares to depart, her screams grow even louder and the knight, feeling a rare moment of empathy, steps off again and goes to the cave. There, he helps the woman deliver her baby and sadly, she dies in childbirth. He wraps the baby around a piece of cloth bearing the royal emblem. "I thought they were all dead," he mutters to himself. Reluctantly, he carries the baby with him and sets off to find the royal castle, where he hopes someone will take care of the child.

After days of weary travelling, one night, he finally reaches the gates of the castle, which is in a dilapidated state and seemingly deserted. For some reason, he doesn't cross the gates. He merely lays the baby in front of the gates

and leaves on his horse. At dawn, he comes back to check on the child and to his dismay, the baby's still exactly where he had left it. Reluctantly, he removes his helmet and the baby takes a good look at him, producing a faint smile after all the crying.

Gathering his courage, the knight puts back his helmet, slides down his visor and steps through the gates. As if passing an invisible barrier, the castle's seemingly ramshackle appearance seems to have been a facade. Once the barrier is crossed, the castle appears to be in better conditions, and men and women slowly emerge from the houses surrounding it. As the knight advances towards them to hand over the baby, he collapses on the ground as if struck by a sudden heart attack. An old woman walks towards him and picks up the baby, who is luckily unscathed. She slowly removes the knight's helmet and instead of a man's face, she finds a skull devoid of any flesh. "Who were you?" she mutters, puzzled by the fact that the knight's armor bore no affiliations to any factions.

Main Plot

June 3, 1968: Alone, Albert Garnier waits for his train to Paris in the quasi-deserted Strasbourg-Ville station. He passes by a few newspaper stands where he glances at newspaper articles celebrating the end of the May 1968 protests. He seems cautiously content that the riots have finally ended. Yet, he lets off an air of sorrow and despondency as if something's gnawing at him.

When his train finally arrives, Albert realizes his tickets are gone. A **man** he vaguely recognizes hands them to him after they had fallen from his pockets. He thanks the man and enters the train. He sits forlornly at a window seat, cogitating over unknown matters. A woman, Sandra Marceux, sits next to him and tries to strike up a conversation but the lonesome Albert isn't the chatty kind. She takes out her book, *The Castle* by Franz Kafka, whilst Albert reads Marcel Proust's *La Fugitive*. Having read Proust's works, Sandra again tries to converse with Albert and he reluctantly caves in. Though initially awkward, Sandra's zestful vibe carries their conversation and Albert grows to enjoy her presence. He praises Proust's ability to connect loss and memory and Sandra accidentally spoils the book for him, much to his amusement.

Their conversation shifts to a debate on the thin line between memory and fantasy, linked to the malleable nature of memories. Albert affirms that memory is inherently rooted in reality and any distortions in recollections are minor and negligible. Sandra disagrees, believing the distinction between what really happened and what someone remembers happened can differ greatly. They then talk about the recurrence of conflicts within Paris: first the Nazis, then the recent riots. Unlike Sandra, Albert disagrees with the CGT's communist ideology, whilst also calling out the union's hypocrisy during their involvement in the protests.

Sandra reveals more about her: she's visiting her deceased husband's parents in Paris. She lost her husband during the 1961 Vitry-Le-François train bombing. When Sandra inquires about Albert's personal life, Albert avoids it completely. Suddenly, Albert notices Sandra's initially **brown** eyes have turned **green**. This inexplicable event provokes a resurgence of memories within him and he ends their conversation, feigning a headache to justify his sudden silence.

July 15, 1942: In a scruffy apartment found at the impoverished 18th arrondissement in Paris, 17 years old Albert takes care of his 10-year-old sister, Celeste. They share a strong bond and Celeste is his only friend in an otherwise lonely life. In the morning, Albert's mother again implores his father to leave Paris with the whole family. As before, he refuses, claiming he still has work to do for the French Resistance. She begs him to cut ties with the Resistance but he is too committed to his position. When she implies he never cared for the family due to his frequent absences, infidelities and alcoholism, he slaps her in a fit of rage and leaves. His parents' frequent fights take its toll on Albert and he perceives his life as only becoming bleaker and bleaker. He contemplates suicide and brings with him a Luger pistol (which he has been hiding under his bed) as he leaves for work. His neighbor Anna, a lonely and retired school teacher, has overheard the ruckus and asks Albert if he's okay. Albert simply nods a yes.

Albert is a server at *Le Café de Henriette*, a cozy café situated between the 9th and 18th arrondissement. With his father in the Resistance and his mother being a housewife, Albert is the family's sole source of income. The place, previously frequented by French ladies and gentlemen, are now marred by the presence of Nazi officers. After failing to salute back "Heil Hitler" to SS-Sturmmann Werner and Hinrich, Hinrich kicks him out of mischief but Werner stops him. Werner has known Albert since the beginning of the occupation and considers him a friend. At the counter, Albert goes back to reading Marcel Proust's *Du côté de chez Swann*. A mysterious and angelic 17 year old Girl suddenly enters the café and walks towards the back, making sure to avoid attention. There, she gestures to the waiter. "I've never seen you here before," he whispers to her. "I heard you help people here," she replies. He retreats to the kitchen and comes back with a small bag of food. The Girl quickly takes it and hides it under her coat. But just as she's about to make a prompt exit, she sees Albert with a book and is overwhelmed by a strange feeling of familiarity. Risking everything, she walks towards him and uses the book to initiate a conversation.

Although her clothes are tainted and smeared in dirt, her beauty remains unblemished. Albert takes note of her *sui generis* appearance as an indication she isn't from Paris. When Hinrich and Werner notice her, Hinrich harasses her. He inquires about her identity, ordering her to present her papers. Albert intervenes and claims she's his sister and Werner persuades Hinrich to leave her alone. For having protected her, she offers to pay her debt in any way Albert would like. Albert is very shy but through their interactions there's an immediate connection even though The Girl won't reveal her name and origin. Ergo, he asks to meet her after his shift so that they can get to know each other. When she leaves, Albert notices a **birthmark** on her right wrist.

In the afternoon, they reunite and Albert lets out that he would have wished to take her out for dinner if his favorite restaurant, *Chez Catherine*, hadn't been destroyed during a bombing raid years ago. She proposes they go to his place but Albert refuses without explaining why. She then suggests simply going with the flow by strolling around Paris. At the 9th arrondissement next to the Palais Garnier, Albert despairs over how the opera is now blemished with swastika flags, hanging like ominous symbols of death. He talks about how the Nazi flags over the Eiffel Tower, Versailles and other renowned areas have destroyed the spirit of the French people.

His mindset and worldview seem to fit the **learned helplessness theory**. After confessing that he feels like everything is hopeless and that the world is sinking into darkness, The Girl retorts that the world still bears some positivity, which will always outweigh the negative. When Albert calls that fantasy, The Girl argues retreating to fantasy as an escape to a harsh reality can be therapeutic. Albert calls her delusional and adopts a misanthropic attitude, calling humans destructive and harmful to each other due to their greed and thirst for power, supported by Nietzsche's Will to Power philosophy, which Albert believes influenced Hitler's genocidal impulses. Albert ponders on the eternal return, specifically past mistakes fated to repeat themselves across eternity. The Girl counters his pessimism through a strong belief in humanity and free-will. She maintains that believing in the eternal return is believing in predeterminism which to her is nonsense and just a justification for one's own shortcomings. Albert, though skeptical, appreciates her honesty and is impressed by her uncompromising ideals.

The Girl is a hopeless romantic but Albert, young and immature, confounds love and obsession and affirms falling for someone only brings pain and suffering due to the insatiable desire to possess the one you love. Albert has formed a complex whereby all he associates with love are negative sentiments but The Girl tells him there's much more to romance than what he's experienced. The Girl asserts that love is more about sacrifice, conquering your fears and insecurities, as well as acceptance. Albert retorts that it's the longing that brings more pain and his impatience is obvious when he ponders on how long he's supposed to keep suffering before things take a turn for the better.

Suddenly, a man named Michael, who **looks exactly** like the man who returned Albert his train tickets in 1968 (**with no age difference**), bursts out of a corner with a stolen bag and warns Albert and The Girl that German soldiers are approaching. Not wanting to deal with any spiteful Nazis, the two run and follow Michael to a bakery where the baker accepts to hide Michael and the two teenagers in his secret basement. It's revealed The Girl has been carrying with her a pet in her coat: a **beautiful white baby dove** she lovingly calls Maxine. In the darkness, the Girl begins hyperventilating as if struck by a terrible memory but she quickly takes a deep breath and regains her composure. Meanwhile, the baker sends the German soldiers on a wild goose chase by claiming he saw Michael dashing to another street. Albert suspects the bag contains stolen weapons but it instead contains booze. Michael has stolen alcohol from drunk German soldiers for a party at the 8th arrondissement and invites both Albert and The Girl, whom he jokingly refers to as Albert's girlfriend. Once the coast is clear, the Girl proposes they go to the party but Albert refuses to go due to his crippling social anxiety. The Girl manages to convince him to tag along by reiterating that he should overcome his fears.

To Michael, they keep the facade that they are brother and sister leading to awkward interactions where they have to pretend they've always known each other. Michael reveals he is a Citroen factory worker but he's also part of the Resistance. Whilst wandering into the pristine 8th arrondissement where the rich used to live, Michael explains that the rich have long left Paris before the German invasion. Thus, there are ample opportunities for the working-class people to frequent areas normally reserved for the wealthier. This includes *La Grande Taverne de Louise Élisabeth*, where the party is taking place.

Once they reach the tavern, Michael vanishes amongst the crowd. It's a jovial scene. Men, women and children, some coming from distant arrondissements, all dancing to some energetic can-can music booming from the gramophone. For this brief moment in time, the war seems nonexistent. There, The Girl wants to dance and the shy Albert reluctantly accepts. It's awkward at first but they both begin to vibe to the music.

Alberts pleads to know more about who The Girl is and where she comes from, promising she can trust him. But The Girl, in turn, promises she'll tell him more in due time. When she asks why Albert doesn't want her in his house, Albert elaborates on his parents' loveless marriage and the disturbing fights that sullies his household. The Girl says he is still young and shouldn't abandon his faith in love because of his parents; he has a lot more to experience. Albert reveals he's keeping a secret as well: he is a Jew who doesn't wear the yellow Star of David. No one else knows his family is Jewish. His family and himself aren't religious but Albert has always been fascinated by the mythologies, especially that of a protective archangel who always stood by humanity, prominently featured in foundational texts of Christianity, Judaism and Islam.

Compelled by his honesty and trust, The Girl reveals she is a princess from a nation she won't specify and that after the death of her parents, the Nazis have been actively looking for her since she is the sole heir to the kingdom. Albert laughs and rebuffs her claims but she removes a pouch from her coat, which contains a seed for a kind of **tree** endemic to her kingdom. She intends to plant it in her country, when she begins rebuilding it after all the bloodshed finally comes to an end. If the Germans get to her first, her country would be hopeless without a leader.

She elaborates on how her nation has long been a hidden oasis where peace, harmony and acceptance reigned. Albert's misanthropic side argues no such nation can exist because humans are inherently flawed but she asks him to trust in humanity's magnanimity more. She argues there's good in everyone and that the world isn't so black and white. When he says he has seen no evidence of humanity's positive qualities, The Girl restates that he must let go of his myopic views and to just, "Find the light." As if on cue, a spotlight shines over the dance floor where an old couple in their 80s dance to Lucienne Boyer's *Parlez-Moi D'amour*.

The Girl claims magic exists in her country but Albert laughs it off. To prove her claims, she asks him to look at her shadow, which has somehow left her body and has become sentient. "Bored", her shadow leaves the tavern into the streets of Paris. Albert and The Girl follow it, whilst avoiding Nazi patrols, and Albert's shadow becomes sentient as well. Maxine swings out of The Girl's coat and excitedly follows their shadows. The shadows dance under the moonlight at *Pont Alexandre III* and kiss, much to the embarrassment of Albert and The Girl, who says, "They're always more daring than us."

Indeed, they're both unsure if a romance would even be possible given the circumstances. But realizing The Girl will never be safe wandering the streets of Paris alone, Albert accepts to bring her home with him and promises to protect her until she's able to return to her kingdom. The Girl posits that Albert is a **wounded healer**, who tries to heal himself by healing others, but warns that he'll have to heal himself first or he might cause more harm than good. Shortly later, the dove returns to The Girl's coat and the shadows return to their owners although there's a swap; The Girl's shadow becomes Albert's and vice-versa.

With still 2 hours left before the Nazi-imposed curfew, The Girl wants to catch a movie. Albert laments how he cannot escape reality in movies anymore but The Girl insists on going to the cinema. At their local theater, they watch Charlie Chaplin's *City Lights* alone. Looking straight into The Girl's **green** eyes, Albert becomes entranced. They both lean for a kiss and succumb to their desires for each other. They make out passionately. This moment is the apex of their romance; two scarred souls finally finding solace in one another.

Albert notices The Girl's green eyes are now **blue**, and this promptly reawakens a disturbing memory he had repressed. When The Girl notices something's preoccupying him, she asks if he's okay. But Albert simply breaks down in tears and cries out that he doesn't deserve her. He reveals that his **shadow**, the same one which became sentient earlier, isn't good and represents the darkness in him. The calm, introverted Albert she has known so far was just a **persona**. The Girl squeezes him between her arms, hoping to comfort him but Albert insists that she hears about his past...

In **June 3, 1940**: A 15 years old Albert watches *City Lights* with his first love Kathryn, who has **blue** eyes. Albert loved the film but Kathryn is unimpressed and is eager to return home. There is no connection between the two but Albert is hopelessly infatuated with her. He clumsily confesses his love for her and she bluntly rejects him, saying her and her family will soon leave France due to the Nazis' victories during the Battle of France. It's only a matter of time before the enemy breaches into Paris and Kathryn's family is rich enough to afford an escape. Albert tries to persuade her to stay, claiming she's the only one he can really connect to despite their obvious lack of chemistry. When she refuses to listen to his cries any longer, Albert lashes out at her, calling her selfish for leaving him. Kathryn retaliates by calling him burdensome. Albert takes her departure very personally (a sign of cognitive distortion) and he knows he can't leave the city with her due to poverty, coupled with his father's stubbornness to remain in Paris.

Albert begs Kathryn to wait for him after the war, so they can reunite and get married. Kathryn feels guilty for Albert's sufferings and as much as Albert has been a great friend to her, she just doesn't share the romantic feelings he has for her. Albert confesses he's been a mess lately with things at home getting worse. He says Kathryn is the only bright spot in his life and with her gone, there will be only despair. But she's done with Albert guilt-tripping her and emotionally blackmailing her to be with him when she clearly doesn't want to. After cooling off, Albert asks if they'll ever meet again, to which she replies, "I don't know but I hope for both our sakes we don't."

Albert tries to apologize for his breakdown when suddenly, deafening explosions echo through the city; it's a bombing raid. Luftwaffe bombers overwhelm the night sky whilst Albert and Kathryn try to make their way through the pandemonium. Like lightning shattering the skies, the anti-aircraft cannons burst through the night. Through crumbled buildings and dismembered corpses, the two try to make their way to the subway station to find refuge. They stumble on the remains of *Chez Catherine*, now a heap of broken glass and bricks laying under a downed Heinkel He-111 bomber. This sight sends Albert in a state of fiery rage and desperation. The Heinkel's pilot fires at the glass cockpit and escapes from the debris. He has lost both of his legs and crawls towards Albert begging for help. Albert seizes the pilot's Luger pistol and shoves it into the pilot's mouth. He

then turns to Kathryn, who's paralyzed with fear, and begs her not to leave him. He pushes the barrel further down the pilot's throat and seems to feel a sadistic satisfaction in doing so. Traumatized by Albert's sadism bursting into full view for the first time before her eyes, Kathryn runs away. This marks the last time they're ever going to see each other. Albert, dejected, pulls the trigger and obliterates the pilot's neck, almost decapitating him.

Back to the night of **July 15, 1942**: The Girl, eyes now **green**, is perturbed by his story but still tries to rationalize Albert's actions. She claims his remorsefulness is a sign that he has changed. Albert fears that whenever he tries to prevent the loss of someone in his life, he ends up doing the very same things that make them leave him thus continuing a vicious cycle of loss and solitude. To The Girl, self-loathing won't lead anywhere and will only worsen his condition. She too once nearly succumbed to despair, after having lost her mother when the Germans raided her family's castle. She powerlessly witnessed her friends and family massacred and has been tormented by survivor's guilt ever since. No kind of magic could save her people from the devastation that would ensue. But the worst part was yet to come. Indeed, it was during her escape to Paris that she underwent the most gruelling chapter of her life.

During **late-1941**: The Girl and her father escaped their country through a secret tunnel. They seem to be the only ones who managed to leave the kingdom. They are unescorted, for the royal guards have all been killed during their daring escape. Now alone and nearly out of provisions, they finally enter the Catacombs of Paris but finding a way out proves to be more challenging than anticipated.

In the darkness, eerie growls break the silence. The growls grow stronger and stronger until the roof collapses, sending rubble and debris in all directions. After the dust settles down, the Girl checks her coat and is relieved to find Maxine unscathed. She scans her surroundings and finds her father in agony, with both his legs broken. The growls are heard again, and the Girl proclaims, "The creature has followed us." She wearily drags her father down the dark and labyrinthine catacombs, surrounded by death in the form of bones and skulls. Whatever she's escaping from, she knows it might be even worse than the Nazis. After a while, exhausted and breathless, the two settle down.

Too afraid of lighting up a fire that could reveal their position to the creature, they remain in the darkness. Her father, weak and delirious, reveals he has always blamed her mother (his wife) for the downfall of their kingdom. He calls her weak and claims her blind optimism, her naivety and her exaggerated views on the power of magic are what caused their ultimate defeat. He knows he has always been strict, distant, and even cruel to the Girl but it was because he wanted her to be better and wiser than her mother. But once he observed her adopting her mother's ideals, he was convinced she would be afflicted by the same weakness. He blamed her for resembling more and more like her mother and tried to impose his misanthropic beliefs onto her during her teenage years, even though she would always turn a deaf ear to his ramblings. Upon realizing his words fell on deaf ears, he became more possessive of her and tried to reduce her time spent with her mother, fearing she would "ruin" his daughter. He would make up excuses to the Queen and the Girl to justify their absence for each other.

He says everything the Girl has insofar witnessed of their kingdom were through her mother's eyes. She showed her what she wanted her to see, making her believe that their country was a perfect utopia. As her father's words sear into her mind, the Girl remembers how whenever she would leave the castle, she would always be escorted by the royal guards and her path would already be mapped out on the eve of her trips. Her mother's overprotectiveness often exacerbated her loneliness, for she didn't have many friends and could rarely go out with them.

Her father then recounts how previous kings and queens have all witnessed wars and unspeakable horrors throughout the kingdom's history and he, himself, killed many in his younger years as a knight. His voice now shakier and weaker, he says that fighting for survival isn't worth it anymore. Even if they manage to leave the catacombs, there will only be darkness on the other side. As his words of resignation echo through the tunnel, the creature's growls manifest again, this time louder than ever. Panicked, the Girl drags her dad with her in a desperate attempt to flee from the creature, which seems to be right around the corner. "It's pointless, let it devour us," he whispers but just then, the Girl, fuelled with burning rage and repressed hatred, grabs a skull from the walls and bashes her father's head with it. His breathing stops and his pulse comes to a halt. As for the creature, its growls have now puzzlingly gone silent. She looks at her father's corpse in disbelief, his head under a growing pool of blood. As the weight of what she has just gone through crashes in, she screams in horror.

Days go by and she's now out of provisions. The only thing protecting her from the cold and the dripping ceilings is her father's coat, which she had taken from his body. Dehydrated and on the verge of starvation, she collapses on the ground and faints. But when she wakes up moments later, she finds an old woman, face smeared in dirt and dressed in ragged clothes, next to her. Without uttering a single word, she offers her food and water. After regaining some strength, the woman takes her by her hand and the two venture through the catacombs. When the Girl attempts to know more about her mysterious savior, the old woman simply replies, "I knew your mother." Throughout their journey, the Girl has frequent fainting spells but the old woman never leaves her side and always waits for her to regain consciousness to continue their journey.

At one instant, the woman hears noises from a nearby German bunker and narrowly evades underground Nazi patrols. However the sight of the Germans is oddly reassuring; it signifies that the exit to the surface might be near. Finally, after weeks of strenuous wanderings through the catacombs, the two find a manhole cover leading to a desolate street in Paris. As the woman opens their exit, the Girl's eyes glitter at the sight of the morning light flooding into the tunnel. The old lady helps her out and once on the surface, the Girl extends her arm to her. But the woman refuses to accompany her. "There are many here like you. I need to help them," she utters before wishing the Girl farewell.

Although she's immensely thankful to her, she is again struck with a sense of loneliness and abandonment as she wanders the streets of Paris, this time with no one by her side. One day, she follows the smell of damp air and finds an abandoned water tunnel that leads to the Montmartre Reservoirs. With nowhere to find shelter, she dreads at the thought of going back into the darkness again but regrettably, there are no other alternatives.

For the months before her fateful encounter with Albert, she lives among rats, dripping ceilings, and faint daylight through storm grates. She only goes out for food. She scavenges markets at dawn, taking leftovers from the trash of bakeries. Sometimes, she'd muster the courage to steal apples and bread from supply trucks. She washes her clothes in the underground cisterns and dries them over air vents. In her father's coat, she finds a few francs which would never have been enough to sustain her. She decides to only spend them when all of her other means of survival fail or when the war ends and she needs to pay for travel expenses to her country. Her only friend through all her ordeals is Maxine. Her pouch, bearing the seed of her kingdom's emblematic tree, serves as a constant reminder of home and a faint symbol of hope that the war will end and she'll finally be able to return to her country.

Back to **July 15, 1942**: The Girl reveals that she was never able to reach the old woman again. Her memories of what happened in the catacombs are murky but she does remember the strange feeling of familiarity she felt when she first laid eyes on the woman. And it was only much later, when she was trying to come to terms with the events inside the catacombs, that she realized the old lady was an older version of her mother. She was exactly how her mother would look if she had survived the German invasion and lived into old age. This phantasmagorical occurrence puzzled her but in her kingdom, such ghostly apparitions were not unheard of.

Albert, a little skeptical, wonders if the Girl might have imagined the whole thing as an act of desperation or if she wanted the old woman to be her mother to convince herself that she never really died. Though initially offended by his remarks, the Girl nevertheless admits Albert could be right. But her experiences are her own and whatever really happened, she still trusts her recollections.

After a weighty silence, Albert asks if she regrets what she did to her dad. The Girl admits that after leaving the catacombs, she long battled with guilt over what she has done. She contemplated ending her life when the crushing sense of remorse and loneliness became too much. But then, she realized killing herself would render the father's death pointless: she convinced herself that if she hadn't killed him, he would have slowed her down and she would have never been able to evade the creature after them. Quite simply, she would have died in the catacombs alongside her father. As for his revelations about the reality of her kingdom during his final moments, the Girl rebuffs them, claiming it was the despair and hopelessness that made her father say such things.

As disturbing as the Girl's story is, Albert feels a strange sense of comfort and reassurance within it. It proved he wasn't alone in his turmoil. All the optimism and zestfulness he's seen in her after all that she'd gone through is even more remarkable now. She confesses that her past still haunts her but she can't afford to let it paralyze her. Whether it's denial, suppression, or plain forgetfulness, she will do what's necessary to keep on living, unanchored by past traumas.

Yet, something about the Girl's story deeply puzzles Albert. If she has been in hiding for so long and is fearful of the Nazis finding her and knowing the truth about her identity, why did she take the risk of approaching him at the cafe? And why wander Paris knowing German patrols could intercept them anytime? The Girl smiles and says that when she saw Albert going into the cafe this morning, she was struck by a strange sense of familiarity. Oddly enough, Albert looked exactly like someone who once saved an ancestor of hers. When asked who that

person is, the Girl reveals she never got to know him. He saved her family's future a long time ago, way before she was even born. Doing so resulted in his death but history never forgot him. The image of what he looks like and why she's so sure Albert looks exactly like him is because through generations, this image passed on through the royal blood and always remained seared into the memories of the royal family.

She knows that as long as she's with Albert, who she believes is some kind of reincarnation of her family's mythical savior, she will always be safe and he will always protect her. Albert, moved by her words, kisses her again.

Her trust allows Albert to confess he also contemplated suicide, and even wanted to end his life at midnight but the day he spent with The Girl convinced him to abandon his plans, now that he has seen there's still "light" in this world. He believes the Girl coming into his life is a fatalistic sign that he should keep on living. Albert acknowledges that at some point she will have to leave for her kingdom once the war ends and thus, he promises to make the most of the time they have left together. The Girl implores him to let go of his dreadful past so that they can both finally move on with their lives, this time no longer alone.

On their way to Albert's apartment, 20 minutes before curfew, they are approached by a drunken Werner and Hinrich. Hinrich pesters them and when Albert demonstrates resistance, things get violent. Hinrich pulls The Girl towards him and Maxine falls out of her coat. Albert tries to intervene but Hinrich kicks him in the face, breaking his nose. As he falls, the Luger pistol slips out of his jacket. Werner sees it and becomes infuriated. It's clear he's no longer going to defend Albert. He questions the boy on where he got the gun but Albert stays silent. Maxine's wings are broken and Werner stomps on the dove, breaking its ribcage and killing it. The Girl screams but Hinrich muffles her screams with his hand. Without hesitation, he pins her against a wall and subjects her to a cruel and unspeakable act. In absolute desperation, Albert snatches the pistol off Werner's hands and shoots at Hinrich. But in a split second, Hinrich uses The Girl to shield himself from the bullet. Blood pours out of The Girl's chest as Albert horrifyingly realizes he just shot her. Werner takes out his service pistol and aims it at Albert. Just as he's about to shoot, an SS-Sturmbannführer comes to his rescue. The Major fires at Werner's face, obliterating it, and fires 3 shots at Hinrich as he tries to flee, also killing him.

The SS Major looks **exactly** like Michael even though he has no knowledge of him. Traumatized and his eyes brimming with tears, Albert holds the dying Girl in his arms while she utters her last words: "Find the light." Albert screams in despair whilst the SS Major tries to comfort him and tell him that they should bury The Girl as soon as possible. Albert picks up Maxine's lifeless body and the two bury The Girl in an abandoned construction site where they're sure no one will find her remains. Albert refuses to bury Maxine's body yet, affirming the dove's the only thing he has left of The Girl and he despairs over the fact that he never even knew her name. Finally, he takes out the pouch bearing the seed and plants it on top of her grave.

Ravaged by guilt, misery and loss, he heads home in tears. On his way, he finds the dead body of his father after he had been shot multiple times. Overwhelmed with dread, he dashes to his apartment, fearing for his mother and Celeste. However, he is stopped by Anna who tells him his father was killed when he went out looking for Albert and that his mother and Celeste were rounded-up at Vel' d'Hiv by the police to be sent to concentration

camps. She reveals she overheard the Nazis talking about how Albert's father had ratted out his family as being Jewish in a hopeless attempt to save his own life in exchange of information on hiding Jews. Anna shelters Albert for the night during the mass arrest of Jews by the French police at the behest of the Germans. Albert is inconsolable; he lost everything in the span of one night and it's all his fault. He sleeps in Anna's son's bedroom. Her son had enlisted in the army and was killed at Dunkirk. After losing everyone, Anna is all he has left.

Albert places Maxine's lifeless body on the table. He still has the Luger pistol with him and removes it from his coat. This time, he's made up his mind. He has nothing left to live for and it's finally time to end it all. But suddenly, the bird twitches and Maxine inexplicably springs back to life. Nothing can describe the marriage of shock and wonderment felt by Albert as he witnesses the dove effortlessly flying out through the window into the Parisian night. Albert watches it fade into the starry sky, with hopeful eyes. He now knows The Girl will live on somewhere beyond this world and for a brief moment, Albert's hopelessness is no more.

Back to **June 3, 1968** in the train: Albert finally breaks out of his trance and tells Sandra that she once loved a foreign girl who died during the war. However, he fails to properly recollect how she died (memory repression) but still feels haunted by a crippling sense of guilt. In the years following the end of the war, all his attempts to find where she had come from proved futile. Everything she had told him about her country didn't help at all and he had to accept that her origins might forever remain a mystery.

Later, when he learned his mother and sister both died at Auschwitz, he succumbed to a crippling depression. He then goes off on a tangent and talks about the Pygmalion mythology, a tale of a lonely sculptor who built a statue representing his idea of someone he desperately needed in that period of his life. He fell in love with his own creation and for him, the statue was as real as a human being. Touched by his love for someone who doesn't even exist, Venus brought the statue to life. Sandra doesn't understand the relevance of this story and Albert refuses to provide any explanation. He then finally decides to reveal why he is going to Paris: it's to discuss the final terms of his divorce with Camille, his wife who has gotten full custody of their children. He laments how guilty he feels for messing things up with her and losing the people he loves, a cycle which seems unbreakable at this point.

Sandra offers to keep in touch with him, saying they might find solace in each other. But Albert's neurosis prevents him from forming any emotional bond with someone due to the fear of loss and the lasting trauma of his younger years. He mentions the Hedgehog's dilemma and all the baggage he carries to justify his inability to form relationships. The thought of repeating his mistakes renders him emotionally distant and he accepts that he is too emotionally demanding, which scares off people. He says nothing good ever lasts but Sandra tells him it's time he lets go of his past to allow himself to move on. When the train reaches *La Gare de l'Est*, she gives him her business card and although he wants to be with her, Albert says he hopes they'll never meet again, a **reaction formation** triggered by what Kathryn told him in 1940. When she leaves despondently, her eyes are still **green** and Albert notices a **birthmark** on her right wrist, identical to The Girl's.

Later during the day, he walks forlornly amidst the detritus of the May 68 protests. He goes to 'The Girl' burial site where an immense exotic tree now stands. It is green, exuberant and full of life, just like her. He also finds an

old woman staring morosely at the tree. Unbeknownst to him, it's the same woman who helped the Girl escape the catacombs in 1941. They lock eyes but don't exchange any words.

A few hours later, he contemplates throwing Sandra's card into the river Seine at *Pont Alexandre III* but he doesn't. There's an internal conflict within him between hope and pessimism and deep inside, he feels like maybe hope is winning.

He finally meets Camille and Albert apologizes for having been a bad husband. Camille ignores his words saying now isn't the time for apologies; it's too late anyway. They go to *La Grande Taverne de Louise Élisabeth* which is still standing, having survived the war. It is as lively and bustling as ever. Albert convinces the owner to play Lucienne Boyer's *Parlez-Moi D'amour* and he asks Camille for one last dance. Camille reluctantly accepts. A spotlight shines above them and just like the old couple, they share a sweet dance.

Throughout their marriage, Albert has rarely seen Camille so jaunty. This, in turn, makes him happy. Can their marriage be salvaged after all? But after the first minute, they both seem to recall why things didn't work out. The pain inflicted on each other. The constant fighting. Albert's possessiveness and anger issues. All these memories seem to come back. As the song nears its end, their cheerfulness, like their love for each other, has faded away. They continue their dance though, for whoever's looking and by courteous obligation.

Albert remembers The Girl's death, Kathryn, the pilot, his parents, Celeste and all his mistakes. All these memories flash in his head. But this time, instead of letting his horrendous past haunt him, he tries to accept it rather than suppressing it like so many times before. Perhaps his self-healing journey can now finally begin. The song ends, the spotlight is switched off, and Albert heaves a sigh of relief.

The End